

UNDP response to 2015 TC Pam

After Action Review

Summary

In 2015, Tropical Cyclone Pam hit Vanuatu and Tuvalu causing great destruction: housing, infrastructure, agriculture, community and public facilities were damaged. Livelihoods, especially in the informal sector, were severely affected. UNDP Fiji Multi-Country Office (now the Pacific Office in Fiji) and the organization globally mobilized for the response.

UNDP undertook immediate crisis response activities such as debris management, Cash for Work (CfW) and emergency livelihoods; it contributed USD 500,000 to the Cyclone Pam Recovery and Resilience in Vanuatu (CPRRV) plan. The organization was, however, not successful in mobilizing resources through humanitarian appeals. Outside of the appeal funding for recovery was mobilized, but it did not meet the projected needs as articulated in the SURGE plan.

UNDP Crisis Response Unit and the MCO conducted in 2016 an After Action Review to learn from the experience, highlighting key successes and enabling factors, as well as gaps and challenges encountered. The AAR is aimed at improving UNDP's future performance; it informs the revision of the Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response and the development of the Crisis Response Packages.

Successes of the response and enabling factors

Corporate support (HQ and RH) and activation of crisis response mechanisms - Corporate support was convened quickly and it was dedicated and positive; with particular mention of the support provided by the Desk Officer in the Regional Hub. Activation of Fast Track Procedures and SOPs and release of immediate funds for Vanuatu were beneficial to kick-start the response. The CB effectively channeled support from multiple units and departments.

Immediate internal resource mobilization – Support from HQ and RBAP provided funds for USD 50,000, USD 350,000 and USD 476,000 (total of USD 876,000) which allowed the MCO to establish an office in Vanuatu and initiate immediate crisis response activities and coordination.

High quality and skills of staff deployed - Deployments provided UNDP with much needed capacity, particularly in Vanuatu; some of the staff deployed have been commended repeatedly as competent, knowledgeable and effective.

High quality and skills of MSB deployments – Ample consensus on quality and skills of the personnel deployed through MSB and their effectiveness even in short-term assignments.

Support provided by MCO staff – Positive contribution of local staff, advising technical experts on the local context and on how to adapt standard solutions to the reality of the country. Good collaboration between MCO staff and incoming responders. In particular, excellent performance reported of the Operations Manager deployed to Vanuatu, later recommended for SURGE deployments.

Rapid scale up of Vanuatu operation and stronger presence in country – Expansion of UNDP office in Vanuatu and establishment of a Vanuatu Special Desk in MCO, increase in staff and programme coherence and team work in Vanuatu, leading to a stronger operation and programme implementation.

Humanitarian leadership and Humanitarian coordination – Immediate appointment of the Humanitarian Coordinator and regular presence in country, positively recognized including by UNDAC. Strong support and civil-military coordination with FRANZ (France, Australia, New Zealand).

Challenges and gaps

Limited presence in Vanuatu and lack of senior representation in Vanuatu office – This was the key initial challenge faced by the MCO. A very limited presence before the disaster, and multiple factors afterwards led to a void in leadership and representation in Vanuatu, which affected in particular UNDP's representation and its resource mobilization efforts.

Lack of preparedness of the MCO – The Fiji MCO did not have a preparedness plan and was not ready to face the multiple challenges posed by TC Pam operation.

Delay in first responders' deployments – Competing engagements and some uncertainties on the new mechanisms following the corporate restructuring delayed the identification and deployment of first responders. This in turn affected the participation to assessments, the technical support to proposal development and resource mobilization, the time allowed for the elaboration of the SURGE Plan.

Limited continuity in SURGE support – Fragmented or short deployments, not replaced after departure, have limited the continuity of the support to the MCO, and in turn the continuity of UNDP's support to the country. In particular for Early Recovery, these issues and the high turnover led to a perception of insufficient technical guidance on ER.

Unsuccessful resource mobilization for humanitarian and recovery funds - The organization was not able to mobilize humanitarian funds. Reasons include the perception of limited UNDP's capacities as a crisis response actor, the classification of its activities as not "life-saving", the lack of an authoritative voice advocating for UNDP's proposals, and delays in developing proposals for a bilateral donor. The external fundraising for the Joint Programme proposal for recovery activities also failed.

Limited knowledge of corporate crisis response and tools – Before TC Pam, some members of the MCO management and staff did not have extended knowledge of corporate crisis response, tools and resources available; training and an increased CO preparedness could have been beneficial.

Quality of programming – The gender equality approach in some of the proposals analyzed is limited; technical support from HQ or RH could have mitigated these difficulties. The Cash for Work approach appears to have been controversial at the beginning and not immediately accepted at local level; in the end, however, the MCO was able to adapt the approach to the local context.

Challenges linked to the context – The remoteness of the area and distance of islands caused difficult movements and a high cost of programming, even for a small emergency. The time difference affected communication and coordination with HQ and RH. After a few weeks, the earthquake in Nepal also diverted resources from other crises, including from the Pacific. The Government of Vanuatu was very keen on taking the lead and having maximum visibility, in fact it requested that all funds be channeled through national structures. This limited the resources channeled through the UN itself, including UNDP. The focus on Vanuatu, who took the brunt of the cyclone, grossly limited any chances to raise funds and develop activities in Tuvalu, even if UNDP led the joint UN presence in Tuvalu, the government appealed for international support immediately and had a very positive relation with UNDP.

Moving forward

UNDP has identified areas for improvement at country level and globally as an organization, as a result of the TC Pam experience. The organization will focus on strengthening resource mobilization and advocacy globally, improving immediate crisis support and the mechanisms for first responders and SURGE deployments. UNDP will also focus on corporate preparedness and capacity building for crisis response, together with the review of the SOPs and the finalization of standard Crisis Response Packages.

In the Pacific Office, the organization will focus on increasing its preparedness and on the steps it can take immediately during the response. It will also strive to better position UNDP on response and early recovery, and to improve its resource mobilization capacities.